More Than a Diversity Win

HIGHER PRODUCTIVITY
Women's inclusion can improve efficiency, attendance and order accuracy

LOWER COSTS
Women employees can generate up to 12% in cost savings

BETTER RETENTION
Ecom Express saved ₹12.5 crore over five years through lower attrition among women

GREATER INNOVATION
Gender-diverse teams can bring fresh perspectives to complex logistics challenges

STRONGER BUSINESS OUTCOMES
Women's representation in leadership is linked to better financial performance



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What Holds Women Back

- Gender bias in hiring, task allocation and promotions
- Limited access to industry networks, mentors
- Weak POSH enforcement, limited access to daycare
- Restrictive regulations around night shifts
- Social norms that constrain mobility and work choices
- Regional differences in safety perceptions
- Inadequate access to public toilets
- Disproportionate burden of unpaid care, domestic work

tenance, chartering, customer behaviour and, eventually, aircraft management.

Rather than spending time trying to win arguments with those who doubted her, she focused on competence. "Confidence without competence doesn't last. Know your numbers. Know your customer. Understand your industry. Do the hard work that nobody sees."

Rejection was part of the process. When she struggled to convince early investors, she learnt to build the business around economics. "Sometimes not getting the money you wanted forces you to become more resourceful, understand your customer better and build a fundamentally stronger business," she says.

For Tekriwal, the lesson is about creating your own route. "Build something valuable. Be persistent. Learn quickly. Take calculated risks. And if the door still does not open? Sometimes the answer is not to knock harder on the same door—it is to build another door."

On the other hand, Reema Kothari joined her family business nearly 14 years ago, but she, too, had to establish her authority from ground up. "Some journeys begin with ambition. Mine began with admiration (for her father Ashok Kothari)," says Kothari, who is Partner at Reema Transport Pvt Ltd. and Chairperson of the Women's Wing at the All India Transport Welfare Association (AITWA). "My parents never made us feel that being daughters made us any less capable. This was never about gender. It was about legacy and love."

Yet, inside the business, establishing authority was a different matter. "People were not accustomed to taking instructions from a young woman." Her decisions were frequently double-checked with senior partners. The workplace did not even have separate washrooms for women. "That may sound small today, but it was symbolic of the environment I was entering."Her response was to modernise the business. She introduced formal SOPs, technology and structured business development, and pushed into cold-chain logistics—a move that proved vital during Covid-19.

Over time, she says, the questions changed from "Why should we listen to Reema?" to "What does Reema think?" That, she believes, is what real acceptance looks like: not women being treated as exceptions, but leaders being